

There was also a revival of interest in classical learning, which was influenced by Greek scholars from the Byzantine Empire, who settled in Italy when Constantinople (the empire's capital) fell in 1453. The émigrés brought with them ancient Greek literary, historical, and philosophical texts, which had been lost to the West, and taught the Italians Greek so they could read and translate the works. This led to the emergence of Renaissance Humanism in Italy, which involved studying the humanities—grammar, rhetoric, history, philosophy, and poetry—and, more broadly, a high regard for the dignity and potential of the human race.

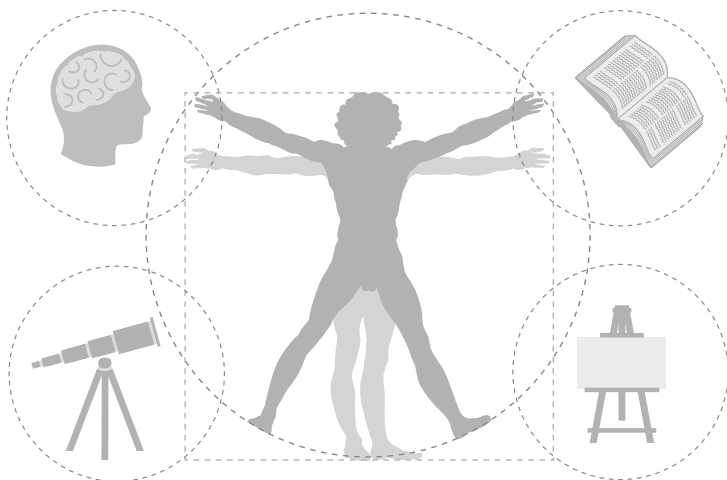
At the time of the Renaissance, life, business, and politics in Italy were dominated by a number of powerful

city-states—mainly Florence, Milan, Ferrara, and Venice—together with Rome, from where the pope could exercise great secular (“temporal”) power as well as being the spiritual head of the Catholic Church. The city-states generated a lot of wealth from trade and—as in the case of Florence—banking. Their ruling families, such as the Gonzaga in Mantua, the d’Este in Ferrara, the Sforza in Milan, and the Medici in Florence, spent lavishly on palaces, churches, and works of art, and became patrons of many great Renaissance artists. These wealthy families also encouraged the revival of classical learning by employing scholars as tutors for their children. In addition, several members of the Medici family became popes.

The idea of the Renaissance Man, whose expertise and curiosity extends to a range of diverse subjects, reflects the great thinkers of the era: polymaths such as Leonardo da Vinci, who mastered disciplines from art to science.

Humanism placed mankind at the center of the universe. It gave the credit for human accomplishments to people instead of God.

The rediscovery of classical texts inspired thinkers to emulate and even surpass the work of philosophers such as Aristotle.



Science and a growing knowledge of how the world works contributed to fields as diverse as architecture and medicine.

Renaissance artists made several great achievements, which were inspired by the discovery of lifelike Greek and Roman sculpture, and aided by a new understanding of perspective.